

AI-Mediated Professional Signaling: Communication, Visibility, and Authenticity in the Age of Generative AI

Brandon Himpfen
Independent Researcher
Toronto, Canada
brandonhimpfen.com

May 19, 2026

Abstract

Generative artificial intelligence is increasingly integrated into professional communication systems, reshaping how individuals participate in digital discourse, produce content, and signal expertise within networked environments. Much current discussion focuses on productivity gains, ethical anxieties, or concerns about authenticity. This paper argues that these discussions often overlook a broader structural transition already underway: the emergence of AI-mediated professional signaling systems.

Rather than treating generative AI solely as a content automation technology, the paper frames it as communication infrastructure that reduces the friction associated with professional participation. AI systems increasingly support the drafting of comments, posts, summaries, newsletters, reports, and strategic communications across professional platforms, collaborative work environments, and independent publishing ecosystems.

The paper introduces a conceptual framework for understanding AI-mediated signaling through the interaction of visibility systems, platform incentives, algorithmic amplification, and human-AI collaborative workflows. It further explores the evolving relationship between optimization and authenticity, arguing that generative AI does not eliminate professional signaling behaviors but operationalizes and scales dynamics already embedded within digital communication environments.

The objective is not to provide a quantitative evaluation of AI-generated communication, but to establish a durable analytical framework that can support future empirical, sociological, organizational, and technological research.

Keywords: generative ai; professional signaling; ai-mediated communication; authenticity; digital platforms; linkedIn; human-ai collaboration; visibility systems

1. Introduction

Professional communication has always functioned as a signaling mechanism. Resumes, conference presentations, published articles, organizational roles, networking, and public contributions communicate competence, credibility, expertise, and social alignment. These signals are not merely decorative. They help observers make judgments under uncertainty, a core function of signaling systems in economic and social life (Spence, 1973; Goffman, 1959).

Digital platforms changed the scale and persistence of professional signaling. Posts, comments, replies, reactions, newsletters, profile updates, and public participation created an environment in which professional identity is increasingly assembled through repeated, visible communication. In this environment, credibility is not signaled only through credentials or formal outputs. It is also signaled through cadence, relevance, interpretive ability, topical fluency, and participation in networked discourse.

Generative artificial intelligence introduces another structural transition. AI systems can now assist professionals in drafting, editing, summarizing, translating, reframing, and distributing communication at significantly lower cognitive and operational cost. In workplaces, generative AI has already been associated with measurable productivity gains in certain communication-intensive tasks (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025). In professional communication studies, AI-assisted writing has been evaluated not only in terms of output quality, but also in terms of perceived professionalism, effectiveness, and authenticity (Coman and Cardon, 2024).

This paper argues that generative AI is not simply automating communication. It is restructuring the operational mechanics of professional signaling itself. The shift is not merely technological. It is infrastructural.

The central claim is that AI-assisted communication should be understood as part of a broader system of AI-mediated professional signaling. In this system, professionals use AI to reduce the friction of participation, shape their public presence, maintain visibility, interpret discourse, and engage with platform incentive structures. The result is neither a simple replacement of human voice nor a straightforward productivity upgrade. It is a reconfiguration of how communication, visibility, and authenticity interact in professional digital environments.

2. Conceptual Scope and Method

This paper is a conceptual framework paper rather than a quantitative study. Its purpose is to define a phenomenon, map its mechanisms, clarify its tensions, and establish a vocabulary for future research. It draws from signaling theory, self-presentation theory, computer-mediated communication, platform studies, and emerging research on generative AI in work and communication.

The paper focuses on professional digital environments, especially platforms and workflows where communication operates as a visible marker of competence or credibility. LinkedIn is a central

example because it combines professional identity, public posting, commenting, recruiting, social proof, and algorithmic distribution. However, the framework is not limited to LinkedIn. It also applies to newsletters, personal websites, internal collaboration tools, professional communities, open source ecosystems, and other environments where public or semi-public communication shapes professional perception.

The paper does not attempt to determine whether AI-assisted communication is inherently authentic or inauthentic. Instead, it examines how authenticity is produced, interpreted, questioned, and operationalized when AI becomes part of the communication workflow. This distinction matters because authenticity is not a purely technical property of text. It is a social judgment made by audiences in context.

3. Professional Signaling Before Generative AI

Professional signaling refers to observable behaviors, outputs, and interactions that communicate competence, credibility, trustworthiness, identity, or affiliation. Signaling theory is especially relevant when observers cannot directly evaluate the full quality of a person, organization, or claim (Spence, 1973). Signals reduce uncertainty by providing interpretable indicators, even when those indicators are imperfect.

Before digital platforms, professional signals were often mediated by institutions. Degrees, job titles, employers, publications, certifications, conference invitations, awards, and references carried meaning because they were difficult to obtain or externally validated. These signals were not always fair or complete, but they were legible.

Digital platforms expanded the signal space. A professional could now demonstrate expertise through frequent commentary, curated resource sharing, open source contributions, public analysis, community participation, and long-form publishing. This changed the relationship between expertise and visibility. Professional credibility became less dependent on formal gatekeeping and more dependent on sustained participation in public or semi-public networks.

This shift did not eliminate strategic self-presentation. It intensified it. Digital profiles, posts, and interactions are forms of impression management (Goffman, 1959). Computer-mediated communication research has long shown that people adapt self-presentation to the affordances and constraints of mediated environments (Walther, 1996). Professional platforms add a further layer because self-presentation is tied not only to identity, but also to career opportunity, hiring, authority, client acquisition, and reputation.

Generative AI enters this environment after signaling has already become communicative, platformed, and persistent. AI does not create the incentive to signal professionally. It changes the cost, scale, and texture of doing so.

4. From Content Creation to Participation Infrastructure

A common framing of generative AI treats it as a content creation tool. This framing is useful but incomplete. In professional contexts, AI is increasingly used not only to generate finished artifacts, but to support participation across many small communication acts.

These acts include drafting a comment, improving the tone of a reply, summarizing a discussion, transforming notes into a post, outlining a newsletter, rewriting a message for a specific audience, or converting an idea into a more legible professional form. Many of these outputs are too small to be considered formal content assets. Yet they matter because professional visibility is often accumulated through repeated micro-participation.

The infrastructure framing is therefore more precise. Generative AI functions as a participation layer. It lowers the effort required to enter a conversation, respond thoughtfully, maintain a publishing cadence, and translate tacit ideas into shareable language. In doing so, it changes the economics of attention and expression.

This does not mean the professional is absent. In many workflows, the human supplies judgment, context, lived experience, domain knowledge, boundaries, and final editorial approval. AI supplies acceleration, structure, language alternatives, and friction reduction. The communicative act becomes mediated rather than purely manual.

This distinction is important because it avoids two weak interpretations. The first is that AI-assisted communication is merely fake human communication. The second is that AI assistance is merely neutral productivity tooling. A more accurate view is that AI becomes part of the professional signaling stack.

5. A Framework for AI-Mediated Professional Signaling

AI-mediated professional signaling can be understood as the interaction of five layers: intent, mediation, artifact, distribution, and interpretation.

Table 1: Layers of AI-mediated professional signaling

Layer	Function	Examples
Intent	The professional purpose behind communication	Relationship building, expertise signaling, clarification, contribution, career visibility
Mediation	The role AI plays in shaping communication	Drafting, editing, summarizing, reframing, tone adjustment, idea expansion
Artifact	The visible communicative output	Comment, post, newsletter, article, profile text, reply, report
Distribution	The platform or channel that surfaces the artifact	LinkedIn feed, newsletter inbox, internal tool, open source forum, professional community
Interpretation	The audience judgment produced by the artifact	Credibility, authenticity, usefulness, professionalism, trust, relevance

This layered model separates the act of communication from the infrastructure that supports it. A LinkedIn comment, for example, is not only a paragraph of text. It is the product of a professional intent, a mediation process, a visible artifact, a distribution system, and an audience interpretation.

The model also explains why debates about AI assistance often become confused. One person may object to the mediation layer because AI was involved. Another may evaluate only the artifact and judge it useful. A platform may optimize for distribution signals such as engagement. The author may understand the act as a genuine expression of their thinking because they shaped and approved it. Authenticity concerns often arise because these layers are collapsed into a single moral question.

6. Visibility Systems and Platform Incentives

Professional platforms are not neutral containers for communication. They are visibility systems. They rank, recommend, suppress, amplify, and contextualize content through algorithmic and social mechanisms. Platform affordances such as profiles, reactions, comments, reposts, groups, feeds, and follower graphs shape what kinds of communication become visible and valuable (Treem and Leonardi, 2013).

In such environments, participation has compounding effects. A professional who comments regularly on relevant posts may become more visible to peers, potential collaborators, recruiters, or audiences. A professional who publishes consistently may become associated with a domain. A professional who responds with clarity and substance may signal judgment and fluency.

Generative AI changes the cost structure of participation within these systems. If drafting a

thoughtful comment previously required substantial attention, AI can reduce the threshold for entry. If maintaining a newsletter or posting cadence required extensive editorial labor, AI can make the workflow more manageable. This does not guarantee quality, but it expands the range of people who can participate consistently.

The platform incentive problem emerges when reduced communication cost produces higher communication volume. If AI assistance increases the number of posts, comments, and replies, audiences may experience greater difficulty distinguishing useful professional contribution from generic optimization. Recent research on AI-generated and AI-assisted communication highlights precisely this tension: AI may improve perceived professionalism in some contexts while also raising concerns about trust, authenticity, and disclosure (Coman and Cardon, 2024; Sahebi et al., 2026).

The key question is not whether AI produces more communication. It is whether platform incentives reward communication that is meaningful, context-aware, and accountable, or communication that is merely frequent, polished, and engagement-optimized.

7. Comments as Micro-Publications

Professional comments deserve special attention because they are often treated as secondary interactions rather than primary artifacts. Yet on platforms such as LinkedIn, a high-quality comment can function as a micro-publication. It can add interpretation, introduce a framework, clarify a tradeoff, challenge a claim, connect domains, or demonstrate judgment in public.

AI-assisted commenting therefore becomes a revealing case of AI-mediated signaling. The comment is small, but the signal can be significant. It communicates what the professional notices, how they reason, how they engage with others, and whether they can contribute without dominating the conversation.

A useful AI-assisted comment is not simply an agreeable reply. It usually performs at least one of four functions: it adds context, identifies a mechanism, names a tension, or asks a better question. These functions are not new. Skilled professionals have always used comments, questions, and replies to signal attention and insight. AI changes the ease with which those communicative forms can be drafted and refined.

This creates an important distinction between automation and augmentation. Fully automated commenting treats participation as a volume game. Augmented commenting treats AI as an editorial assistant that helps a human express an actual judgment more clearly. The first weakens trust. The second may improve participation, especially for professionals who have relevant ideas but limited time, confidence, or fluency in public writing.

8. Authenticity as a Social Judgment

Authenticity is often discussed as if it were a binary property: a communication is either authentic or not. AI complicates this assumption.

A professional may use AI to improve grammar, shorten a post, structure a comment, or translate a rough idea into clearer prose. The resulting communication may still reflect the professional's judgment, experience, and intent. Conversely, a communication written entirely without AI may still be performative, manipulative, derivative, or strategically optimized.

Authenticity is therefore better understood as a social judgment produced by the relationship between author, process, artifact, audience, and context. This aligns with broader understandings of mediated self-presentation, where identity is performed through available tools and interpreted by observers (Goffman, 1959; Walther, 1996).

AI introduces a new authenticity problem because the mediation process becomes less visible. Audiences may not know whether a message was drafted manually, edited by AI, generated from a prompt, or produced through an iterative human-AI workflow. Disclosure can help, but disclosure also introduces its own problems. Research on AI-mediated communication has identified a disclosure paradox: audiences may say they value disclosure while penalizing communication once AI involvement is disclosed (Sahebi et al., 2026).

This creates a structural tension. If disclosure reduces trust regardless of the quality or human role behind the communication, professionals may face incentives not to disclose. If non-disclosure becomes widespread, audiences may become more suspicious of all polished communication. The result is not simply an ethical dilemma for individual users. It is a system-level trust problem.

9. Optimization and the Risk of Communicative Homogenization

AI-assisted communication can improve clarity, consistency, and accessibility. It can also produce sameness. When many professionals use similar tools, prompts, templates, and stylistic conventions, professional communication may converge toward familiar patterns: polished openings, balanced paragraphs, predictable takeaways, and generic calls for reflection.

This risk is not unique to AI. Professional communication was already shaped by templates, personal branding advice, corporate communication norms, search optimization, and platform-specific best practices. AI accelerates the tendency by making optimized forms easier to reproduce.

The risk is not that AI makes all communication artificial. The deeper risk is that optimization becomes more legible than substance. When the surface markers of thoughtfulness are easy to generate, audiences may need new ways to evaluate credibility. These may include specificity, consistency over time, connection to actual work, willingness to make concrete distinctions, transparent reasoning, and evidence of real domain engagement.

In this environment, authenticity may shift from being judged primarily by tone to being judged by traceability. Audiences may increasingly ask whether a professional’s communication connects to durable work, public artifacts, documented experience, useful frameworks, or observable contributions.

10. Human-AI Collaborative Communication

The most durable model is unlikely to be either fully human manual communication or fully automated AI communication. The more plausible steady state is human-AI collaborative communication.

In this model, AI supports ideation, structuring, drafting, compression, expansion, editing, and audience adaptation. Humans retain responsibility for judgment, factual accuracy, relevance, values, context, and consequences. The professional voice becomes not the absence of tools, but the disciplined use of tools under human direction.

This model is already familiar in other domains. Professionals use spreadsheets, templates, editors, search engines, grammar tools, customer relationship systems, design software, analytics dashboards, and publication workflows. These tools mediate professional output without necessarily eliminating human authorship. Generative AI is more disruptive because it mediates language itself, which is closely tied to identity, intention, and trust.

A rigorous approach to AI-assisted communication should therefore focus less on whether AI was used and more on how it was used. Important distinctions include whether AI supplied structure or substance, whether the human verified claims, whether the message reflects lived judgment, whether the output is responsive to context, and whether the communication creates value for its audience.

11. A Typology of AI-Mediated Professional Communication

Not all AI-assisted communication should be evaluated the same way. The following typology distinguishes between common modes of use.

Table 2: Typology of AI-mediated professional communication

Mode	Description	Primary risk
Editorial assistance	AI improves clarity, grammar, structure, or length while preserving the author’s substance	Over-polishing or loss of personal texture
Idea development	AI helps expand, contrast, organize, or test an author’s rough idea	Mistaking plausible structure for validated insight

Mode	Description	Primary risk
Contextual participation	AI helps draft comments or replies based on a human-supplied judgment	Generic engagement or insufficient attention to context
Content repurposing	AI converts one artifact into another format, such as notes into a post or an article into a summary	Flattening nuance across formats
Strategic positioning	AI helps align communication with audience, platform, or professional goals	Excessive optimization or performative expertise
Automated presence	AI produces communication with minimal human review or involvement	Trust erosion, inaccuracy, spam, and reputational damage

The typology suggests that the ethical and professional stakes depend heavily on the mode of use. Editorial assistance and idea development may be compatible with authentic professional expression. Automated presence is more likely to undermine trust because it simulates participation without sufficient human attention.

12. Implications for Professional Practice

AI-mediated professional signaling creates practical implications for individuals, organizations, and platforms.

For individuals, the challenge is to develop a communication practice that uses AI without outsourcing judgment. Professionals will need to distinguish between sounding credible and being credible. They will also need to preserve specificity, context, and connection to actual work.

For organizations, the challenge is governance. AI-assisted communication may improve productivity, but it also creates risks related to confidentiality, accuracy, compliance, brand voice, disclosure, and employee development. Organizations should avoid treating AI writing tools as simple efficiency upgrades. They are communication infrastructure and should be governed accordingly.

For platforms, the challenge is incentive design. If platforms reward generic engagement, AI will scale generic engagement. If platforms reward substance, relevance, and accountable contribution, AI may help more professionals participate meaningfully. Platform design will influence whether AI-mediated signaling becomes a trust problem or a participation opportunity.

13. Research Agenda

This framework points toward several future research directions.

First, empirical studies could examine how audiences perceive different levels of AI involvement in professional communication. These studies should distinguish between editing, drafting, co-writing, and full automation rather than treating AI use as a single category.

Second, platform studies could examine whether AI assistance changes posting frequency, commenting behavior, audience engagement, and professional visibility. Emerging research on generative AI and LinkedIn posting behavior suggests this is a promising area for further study (Birjandi, 2026).

Third, organizational research could investigate how AI-assisted communication affects workplace learning, professional development, and the formation of junior employees' communication skills. Productivity gains may be meaningful, but they should be evaluated alongside capability development.

Fourth, communication ethics research could examine disclosure norms. The disclosure paradox raises a difficult question: how can AI involvement be communicated in ways that support trust without reducing complex human-AI workflows to simplistic labels?

Fifth, design research could explore tools that preserve human judgment while making AI assistance more transparent, contextual, and accountable.

14. Conclusion

Generative AI is changing professional communication not only by producing text, but by altering the cost, cadence, and infrastructure of participation. In professional digital environments, communication functions as a signal. It communicates expertise, judgment, relevance, trustworthiness, and presence.

AI-mediated professional signaling names the emerging system in which generative AI supports, shapes, and scales these signals. The phenomenon is broader than AI-generated posts and more subtle than automation. It includes comments, replies, summaries, newsletters, profiles, internal communications, and other artifacts through which professionals become visible and legible to others.

The central issue is not whether AI makes professional communication authentic or inauthentic. The deeper question is how authenticity, credibility, and trust are interpreted when communication is increasingly mediated by intelligent systems.

A durable response requires more than productivity advice or moral panic. It requires a framework for understanding how professional signaling works when human judgment, platform incentives, and AI mediation operate together.

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